Key (1949) laid the foundation of political science's understanding of state parties, yet he also left the field with a riddle. Although Key explained well the weakness of state parties in the South, and conversely their strength in the North and Midwest, he left unexplained the West's fierce electoral competition and weak party system. In *National Elections and the Autonomy of the American State Party Systems,* Gimpel (1996) looks to explain this riddle of Western party weakness. Using a variety of data sources, Gimpel examines party coalitions in both the western and eastern United States, to determine how different coalition structures have led to weaker parties. Although Gimpel adds to the field's understanding of party structures, his argument is weakened by his vague operationalization of core concepts as well as by the limitations of the methods he uses to investigate party coalitions.

In the first section, I will outline Gimpel's theory and its implications. In this section, I will also discuss how Gimpel defines his concepts and suggest how they might be better specified. I will next examine the data that Gimpel uses to analyze party coalitions and detail how he might improve party coalition identification by using other data or methods. Finally, I will address how future research might expand upon Gimpel's theories, and contribute to the field's undersanding of party strength throughout the United States.

Section I: Theory and Concepts

Gimpel's theory is based off the presence of different electoral coalitions within states. In the East and Midwest, party coalitions have followed similar demographic cleavages, these same cleavages have then divided the national coalitions for the Democratic and Republican parties. The electorate was divided between whites and minorities; urban and rural; and manufacturing and non-manufacturing. In the West, though, these cleavages were not salient for a variety of reasons particular to each state. For example, in the Northwest the population is predominantly

white and the majority of the economy is not focused on heavy manufacturing. Candidates are then unable to rely on national cleavages over economic issues while running for office, so the parties become disconnected from national politics. In addition, Gimpel argues that when these groups are present in the West they tend to be less concentrated, making machine politics unlikely. Finally, a high rate of immigration to the West and within the West means that there can be little coherence in the electorate between elections.

I will elaborate more in the next section on how Gimpel analyzes these demographic factors, but prior to that is important to highlight what Gimpel means when he discusses Party strength. Gimpel never provides a singular explanation for what Party strength is. Throughout the book he refers to multiple measures: the number of contested primaries, Mayhew's (1986) survey of party strength, the partisan swings between elections, the disparity between national victories and state victories, and the rise of candidate centered elections. Each of these reflects a different aspect of party strength, but it is not clear if they cohere. Party strength could mean the ability of a party to act as a gatekeeper to candidates running for office, or their ability to get candidates elected, or finally the coherence of their party coalitions once in office. A weakness in any one measure does not necessarily mean a weakness in other measures as well.

Gimpel continues to return to the idea of candidate centered elections as the paramount signal of weak parties. He presents this as evidence not only that Western parties are weak but also as evidence of recent change in eastern parties. Gimpel, though, does not account for the general change in campaigning where national elections have become candidate centered (Aldrich 1995). In addition, although this might provide evidence that parties are not as important in electing candidates, this is not necessarily true. Parties have responded to this

change, and often are an important source of consultants and other campaign staff to help candidate centered elections (Aldrich 1995).

Gimpel could have strengthened his theory by elaborating on how party strength is defined. This would have clarified concepts as well as potentially provided some more directly testable hypothesis. Instead, Gimpel's analysis focuses on describing coalitions as the independent variable, and he leaves relatively untested the validity of his dependent variable of party strength.

Section II: Data Analysis

Two types of analysis dominate Gimpel's quantitative investigate of coalitions at the state level. He first examines election results at the county level for statewide office. Using OLS regression, Gimpel builds models of Republican support for each election, using county data on median income, percentage manufacturing, percentage non-white and percentage urban. He then examines exit polling data using available demographic indicators (race, union/non-union and income) to build similar Logit models of Republican support. The purpose of both sets of analysis is to compare the determinants of Republican support in the West to support in the East and to demonstrate that the cleavages matter less in the West. This is done mainly through highlighting the lack of significant coefficients in the analysis of western states.

Gimpel uses both sets of data for practical and theoretical reasons. Practically, exit polling data is only available in recent elections, and in some cases does not contain all the necessary demographic data. Theoretically though, the two data sets reveal different facts about the electorate. For example, in California, examining exit polling alone, Gimpel finds that the local cleavages are similar to the national cleavages. It is only by examining county data that Gimpel reveals the disparity between the two cleavages. The reason for this, according to

Gimpel, is that although California might have similar cleavages the coalition groups are not centralized. This dispersion only reveals itself through an examination of the county data. Gimpel argues that centralization of groups is necessary to build a strong party; elites need to not only have cleavages but also be able to build an apparatus around them, which can only exist if there is a centralization of interests.

Although Gimpel is forward thinking by examining both sets of data, he is still missing important information. The coefficients that Gimpel estimates do not create a measure of how important a constituent group is to a party coalition, but rather how much their presence relates to the overall support of the party within the county. It does not reveal the relative importance of each group within a party coalition and how much they make up of the overall party coalition. For the reasons listed above, Brown (1995) opposes the use of OLS coefficients to compare party coalition and instead proposes a relatively simple tool to measure coalition groups. Brown takes the number of voters within a demographic group in party and divides that by the total number of members of the party to find the strength of each group within that party. Using this calculation he is able to distinguish between cases where, for example, minorities might predominately vote for a single party even though they make up only a small proportion of the party coalition and cases where minorities actually make up a large proportion of the party coalition. Gimpel's method is unable to make this distinction.

In addition, county-level data might still lack necessary precision. In a state like California, counties can be substantial in geographic size and population[1]. In these large counties it is possible for there to be enclaves where a party could still build a sizable machine. Counties are also not always politically salient which is important, since Gimpel's argument rests on how

[1] In 1970, Los Angeles County had a population of 7 million while Ohio had a total population of 10.6 million. Similarly San Bernardino County covers 20,000 square miles while New Jersey covers only 8,000 square miles.

elites view possible political coalitions. If counties lack importance to political elites, they are unlikely to care about the demographic breakdown within counties.

Finally, through his analysis of Western politics, Gimpel highlights the transient nature of voters there. Voters are both consistently moving into the West as well as moving around within the West. Gimpel argues that this adds to the difficulty to build coalitions as there is little stability between elections. Although Gimpel presents some data as evidence it is only investigated in a shallow way. Future analysis might be improved by using county level migration data to see how it effects the coefficient estimates. This would be particularly interesting as it could be theorized that strong parties are able to build coalitions of new immigrants who are politically naïve, and therefore more likely to listen to elites.

Section III: Conclusion

Gimpel constructs the foundation of a compelling theory regarding state party strength throughout the United States. Scholars can build upon his efforts in two ways. First, they can better specify his core concepts. Second, they can apply new methods and data to evaluate it. The concept of party strength needs to be refocused. Researchers must develop testable theories as to what it means for a party to be strong or weak at a variety of levels of party organization. New methods can expand upon our understanding of coalitions, looking at different levels of observation and variables of observations.

Beyond this, Gimpel also opened a door to explore the use of candidate centered elections. Although not the main focus of his argument, it is a theme of his book. Future work can investigate not only the state level but the national and local level, for the determinants of candidate centered elections. This could further our understanding of political parties and how they have varied over time.

Works Cited

Aldrich, John. 1995. *Why Parties?* Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Brown, Robert D. 1995. "Party Cleavages and Welfare Effort in the American States." *American Political Science Review.* 89(1): 23-33.

Gimpel, James. 1996. *National Elections and the Autonomy of American State Party Systems*. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press.

Key, V.O. 1949. *Southern Politics in State and Nation.* Vintage Books.

Mayhew, David R. 1986. *Placing Parties in American Politics.* Princeton: Princeton University Press.